



Station to Station: Kazuo Ishiguro's Top Ten Train Films

Runaway Train

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Director: Andrei Konchalovsky

Production Companies: Cannon Films Inc, Northbrook Films

Executive Producers: Roger Whitmore, Henry T. Weinstein, Robert A. Goldston

Producers: Menahem Golan, Yoram Globus

Associate Producer: Mati Raz

Production Executive: Sue Baden-Powell

Production Manager: Christopher Pearce

Production Co-ordinators: Mary McLaglen, Kassie O'Connell

Location Managers: Phil Christon, Larry Litton

Production Assistants: Jay Scherrick,

Zachary Spoon, Mark Jones, Laura 'Smitty' Smith,

Amy J. Hall, Sean Toohey, Jim Bachelor

Production Assistant (Alaska): Heather Buchanan

2nd Unit Director (Alaska): Max Kleven

Assistant Directors: Jack Cummins, Nancy King, Michael Pariser

Screenplay: Djordje Milicevic, Paul Zindel, Edward Bunker

Original Screenplay: Akira Kurosawa

Director of Photography: Alan Hume

2nd Unit Photography (Alaska): Don Burgess

Camera Operator: Mike Frift

2nd Camera Operators: Alan Caso, Julio Macat

Camera Operator (Alaska): Tom Priestley Jr

Video Playback: Intervideo, Raymond Hirsch

Special Effects: Keith Richins, Rick Josephson, Bob Riggs

Special Effects (Alaska): Tassilo Baur, Ray Brown, Ermanno Biamonte

Crash Sequence:

Cannon Visual Effects Department

Editors: Henry Richardson, Peter Weatherley

Production Designer: Stephen Marsh

Art Director: Joseph T. Garrity

Set Decorator: Anne Kuljian

Set Dresser: Susan J. Ermswiller

Head Scenic Artists: Kelly Deco, Gary Schoeneck

Scenic Artist (Alaska): Jay Burkhardt

Storyboard Artist: Alan Munro

Costume Designer: Kathy Dover

Key Costumers: Jackie Johnson, Beth Holmes

Wardrobe/Makeup (Alaska): Owen Garner III

Makeup Supervisors: Mony Mansano, Lilly Benyair

Titles: Camera Effects

Opticals: General Screen Enterprises,

Optical Film Effects

Music Composed and Conducted by: Trevor Jones

Music Recording: Paul Hulme

Sound Recording: Susumu Tukunow

Sound Recording (Alaska): Neal Thomas

Sound Re-recording: John Hayward

Sound Editor: Jim Roddan

Dialogue Editor: Martin Evans

Train Sound Effects: Ken Johnson, Alan Howarth

Electronic Sound Effects Editor: Michael Hart

ADR Editor: Nigel Galt

Stunt Co-ordinator: Loren Janes

Stunts: Russell Solberg, Terry Jackson, Jean

Malahni, John-Clay Scott, Bob Terhune, Mike

Johnson, Chick Hicks, Stefan Gudju, John Casino,

Dick Durock, Carl Ciarfallo, Doc Duhane

Railroad Consultant: Robert M. Klempner

Railroad Co-ordinators (Alaska): Ted Hewitt,

Douglas Schwartz, Norman Pomeroy

Animal Wrangler: Brian McMillan

Helicopter Pilots (Alaska): Harry Hauss,

Soren Jensen, Rick Holley

Two convicts break out of a hellish prison to find themselves trapped on a speeding train they can't control. Is this Jon Voight's finest moment? (He and Roberts both received Oscar nominations.) On the surface very American, this superb edge-of-the-seat existentialist parable was directed by Russian Andrei Konchalovsky and based on an unproduced Akira Kurosawa screenplay.

Kazuo Ishiguro

A contemporary review

On a visit to California in 1975, the year he was recruited by Mosfilm to direct his most famous work, the epic *Siberiade*, Andrei Konchalovsky told *Variety* that he did not feel he could make a film in the West. 'I am spoiled by having been able to work under our conditions, without economic pressures. In the Soviet Union, films are produced without a constant eye on their commercial success. That may in part explain the slowness, the lack of suspense in a Western sense, that is sometimes found in our films.' Five years later, the Soviet Union having granted him permission to work abroad without closing the door behind him (he has a blameless artistic pedigree and his father, Sergei Mikhalkov, is a leading member of the Union of Soviet Writers), Konchalovsky arrived in Hollywood looking for backers. 'There are different kinds of monkey. Curious monkey and monkey who is not curious. Monkey who is curious go from the forest to the savanna.'

Konchalovsky found a friend in the Cannon Group, and although his first American film, the elegiac *Maria's Lovers* (completed in October 1983, but not released in the U.S. until January 1985, and then with no clear strategy), failed at the box office, the famously tight-budgeted Golan and Globus both liked it and were eager to work with Konchalovsky again. He was signed by Cannon for a series of projects, beginning with the 'action adventure' *Runaway Train*, a film as different in pace, tone and subject matter from *Maria's Lovers* as, one imagines, Godard's *King Lear* (forthcoming from Cannon) will be from the *Popsicle* cycle. The savanna is full of surprises.

Runaway Train, which is set in that former spur of the Russian Empire, Alaska, ends with a quote from *Richard III*: 'No beast so fierce but knows some touch of pity.' It has about it a good deal of what might be termed Hollywood Russia, notably a large dose of undiluted symbolism. The last shot bangs the message home (the story is Kurosawa's, but he would have done it differently): the stigmatised Manny, arms outstretched, balanced on top of the pounding locomotive, headed for the jaws of Hell (or Heaven). The snowy wastes might be Siberian: Konchalovsky claims the idea for his true Siberian epic first struck him on a flight across America, looking down on the variety of landscapes below. And the empty 'Russian' vastness of the landscape is caught, in particular, by one beautiful long shot of the train, in the foreground of which a family of moose are glimpsed lumbering through the snow. The film is marked too by a sort of grandiose fatalism popularly associated with Dostoevsky and here carried through with a wholly un-American seriousness of purpose.

In other respects, however, the epitaph and the symbolism aside, *Runaway Train* is very much an all-action Cannon yarn. Unlike his fellow expatriate Tarkovsky (whose *Andrei Rublev* he co-scripted), Konchalovsky has shown

Cast:

Jon Voight (*Manny*)
Eric Roberts (*Buck*)
Rebecca De Mornay (*Sara*)
Kyle T. Heffner (*Frank Barstow*)
John P. Ryan (*Warden Ranken*)
T.K. Carter (*Dave Prince*)
Kenneth McMillan (*Eddie MacDonald*)
Stacey Pickren (*Ruby*)
Walter Wyatt (*Conlan*)
Edward Bunker (*Jonah*)
Reid Cruickshanks (*Al Turner*)
Michael Lee Gogin (*short con*)
John Bloom (*tall con*)
Norton E. (Hank) Warden (*old con*)
John Otrin (*cat con*)
Norman Alexander Gibbs (*queen con*)
Dennis Ott, Don Pugsley, John Fountain (*guards*)
Wally Rose (*announcer*)
Danny Trejo (*boxer*)
Big Yank (*trainer*)
Tom 'Tiny' Lister Jr (*Black guard*)
Dana Belgarde (*prison guard*)
Diane Erickson (*Sue Majors*)
Larry John Meyers (*Pulasky*)
Don McLaughlin (*Foreman Cassidy*)
Vladimir Bibic (*Fireman Wright*)
William Tregoe Jr. (*Rogers*)
Loren Janes (*Engineer Eastbound 12*)
Obie Weeks (*head brakeman*)
John-Clay Scott (*Conductor Eastbound 12*)
Robert M. Klemptner (*Cushman*)
Carmen Filpi (*signal maintainer*)
Phillip Earl (*1st crewman*)
Tom Keenan (*2nd crewman*)
Tony Epper (*hitman*)
Jerry Brainum (*bodybuilder*)
Duey Thomasick (*emergency worker*)
USA 1985
110 mins
Digital

himself more than adept at serving up a certain kind of Western product. Beginning with a tingling credit sequence, an explosion of beautifully edited violence at the ringside, and then a cunning escape (the bars that have to be prised apart are in a sewage pipe), *Runaway Train* is an exemplary demonstration, executed with great gusto, of how to banish slowness and pump up suspense. It is also, it must be said, an example of a certain kind of Hollywood silliness. Warden Ranken is all brooding vengefulness; Manny, the burnt-out lag who knows it's too late to remake his life, can still solemnly scold admiring young Buck for wanting to copy him; Sara, a freckled tomboy with ragdoll bunches and heart-shaped earrings, is the complete plucky girl; and so on. The characters are all pretty much cut from cardboard and, given the plot, are no worse for that.

But Konchalovsky is by no means a one-note director. He balances the scenes in the train with those, pitched quite differently, in the control room; and there is a nicely judged thread of comedy running through the latter (a dreamy, voluptuous secretary, for instance, floats through the crisis sublimely unaware, apparently, of what is going on). There is, too, a moment of fortuitous melancholy: the young computer wizard is ruminating on the uselessness of his expensive equipment while in the background a television shows a perfect touchdown by the space shuttle – '... a picture-perfect mission, one that is always hoped for but rarely achieved.' In a film in which the action was less well-crafted, and the spectator not being propelled relentlessly from scene to scene, this moment might have stopped the plot dead: that it does not is a considerable tribute to Konchalovsky and his editor Henry Richardson.

The film is handsomely photographed by Alan Hume, the predominant tone being a blue-grey metallic sheen; the prison scenes have a raw, nervy quality which makes one forget their familiarity; and, at the centre, Jon Voight as Manny (an impressive job of uglification by the make-up artist) has old-fashioned star presence courtesy of the Method School.

John Pym, *Monthly Film Bulletin*, June 1986

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